

MATTER OF LIGHT

written by

B.L. Barkey

Adapted from the novel
ANCHOR STONE

Abridged for the Higgsfield Global Film Festival.
Runtime target 5:00 · 2.39:1 · three movements, interleaved.

FADE IN:

EXT. MACHIRA - FROM ORBIT - DAY

A blue-green world hangs in black space. Deep oceans, scattered islands, weather moving in living spirals. It looks like Earth. It is not.

CAEDOM (V.O.)

The planet of Machira was made kindred to Earth, and passed through the same crucibles. It too carried humankind -- blessed, cursed -- and bore their lives and their aspirations.

Closer. Centuries slide beneath us. Forests catch light -- then catch fire. The whole visible face of the world burns.

CAEDOM (V.O.)

As they grew strong, they lost their empathy. At the summit of their craft the world burned entire, in what the survivors named the Long Fire.

The flames gutter out. Green returns, island by island. Reefs bloom in the shallows like paint dropped in water.

CAEDOM (V.O.)

What followed was a millennium of peace. A thousand years of a happiness once thought impossible here.

A shadow slides across the ocean. Not weather.

CAEDOM (V.O.)

It would not be the last tragedy to strike this world. The final act was waiting -- on the release of the Vesper.

CUT TO:

EXT. THE SUN - COURTYARD OF WORLDS - CONTINUOUS

Rising out of liquid white-gold flame: a courtyard built from solidified beams of light, standing untouched in the fire of a star. Its flowerbeds are planted with WORLDS --

small living planets on stems, turning, each with its own weather.

Two beings garbed in robes of light stand at the courtyard's far edge, backs to us, looking down.

CAEDOM -- ageless, lit faintly from within, long white hair, utterly still. Beside him his daughter, ORIANE -- mid thirties, dark-haired, a faceted crystal sheen lying over her robes like frost. Beneath them, far below, hangs the blue-green world.

ORIANE

I don't understand. Why release him again, if we know he could annihilate everything?

CAEDOM

He will almost surely annihilate everything. But it is the way. Balance. There must be risk if there is to be growth.

ORIANE

Yes, but -- we have come so far. Caedom turns to her. He speaks each name with complete understanding.

CAEDOM

Bearer of the Founding Stone. Speaker of worlds. Leader of spirits. Angel of light. Auren. Oriane. Daughter. Please. Trust me. She half-smiles. It doesn't hold.

ORIANE

He was so close last time. He has had a thousand more years to plan. He is cunning. He is dangerous.

CAEDOM

He is all of these things.

ORIANE

He could erase everything. Even the planets before this one. Even Earth.

A beat. The star roars softly below them, like distant surf.

ORIANE (CONT'D)

He's your brother.

CAEDOM

I know.

ORIANE

Then why?

Caedom takes her face gently in both hands. Unhurried.

CAEDOM

Leave the whys to me, child. That is trust. If you trust me first, the answers will come after. Look in your heart, and the fusion within.

She nods. Her eyes are wet and do not spill.

ORIANE

But I'm terrified I cannot see the end.

CAEDOM

So it must be. Do you understand?

A trembling smile. Then, smaller --

ORIANE

Are you sure you're not God?

Caedom chuckles -- and looks into the sun, untouched.

CAEDOM

To a firefly, the eagle is a god. To the minnow, the whale. The word only means a power beyond the place you stand. You are the seed who can become the tree. The pebble, the mountain. But the One you name? I am not him.

He rubs his hands together, and winks.

CAEDOM (CONT'D)

He is real, though he does not exist. I would say no more.

ORIANE

So it begins, and so it ends.

CAEDOM

Ori of the Wind. You know that nothing truly ends.

ORIANE

Yes. But I know there are two
meanings buried there.

He laughs. Together they watch the massive orb of her world -- the third rock from this Sun. A long silence.

CAEDOM
Gather the others. All seven. The
time is approaching.

ORIANE
When will you release him?
Caedom looks down upon Machira.

CAEDOM
Tomorrow.
A single tear rolls down his cheek, falls to the floor of
light -- and FREEZES.

CLOSER. Closer still. One facet of the frozen tear fills
the
frame. Inside it: a moving, luminous blue --

MATCH CUT TO:

EXT. OPEN OCEAN - MACHIRA - STORM - DAY

CARD: 108 YEARS LATER

-- the blue is OCEAN, storm-torn, seen at speed. Wind whips
through Oriane's hair as she rushes over the surface of the
sea, the water tearing past in horizontal streaks.

Warden of one of the seven veiled Verge Isles, she does not
fear the leviathans below. What follows behind her is
worse.

Sixteen dark figures cross the water in loose, disciplined
formation. Some are carried limp by the others, arms
trailing -- puppets on invisible string.

She breathes in deep -- and relaxes, in the eye of the
gathering storm.

A WALL OF OCEAN stands up in front of her and goes over to
grey ice. She veers left; the wall extends, cutting her
off.

She braces -- IMPACT. The ice fractures. She doesn't. Her
crystal-sheathed body is unscathed against it, hair spread,
pressed flat.

Space bends around her -- a HOLLOW, a lens of warped air --
and the atmosphere itself throws her skyward. Her bare feet
blur up the vertical face.

Behind her a pursuer is ripped violently backward mid-air, as if yanked by the spine. He drops away. The wall loses cohesion and collapses into a mountain of seawater.

EXT. MACRE BEACH - CAIRN ISLAND - SAME DAY

Sunlight. Warmth. The first warm frame in minutes.

Two boys burst from the treeline onto sand that is faintly iridescent -- pinks and pale greens alive in the grain.

ALDER (8 today) -- blonde, salt-stiff hair, the longer face,
a gaze that is older than the rest of him. His brother WREN
(6 and a half) -- brown-haired, round-faced, never still,
never quiet. They are exactly the same height.

WREN

Do you really think we can make it
the whole way?

Alder grins -- and shoves him, taking off for the shore.

WREN (CONT'D)

Suckerfish!

Wren chases. They stop at the receding foam of the tide.
Across three miles of reef, a white temple sits on a
distant
isle.

WREN (CONT'D)

You know what they'll do to us if
they catch us, right?

Alder pulls his hands up into claws, voice a rasp --

ALDER

Hang us by our toenails and leave
us for the gulls!

Wren cracks up. Then, really asking --

WREN

No, but really. It's one of the few
things we're forbidden to do. Only
Keepers can step foot on their
Isle. Isn't it almost...
disrespectful?

ALDER

Since when do we care about stuff
like that? If anything, they should
reward us. Swimming the Bloom,
gliding over the bottomless abyss,
slipping the last reef -- all in
one go.

WREN

Okay. Let's do it.

They shed their outer tunics and dive into the tide.

Far out over the open water, low on the horizon: ONE DARK CLOUD. It does not move with the others.

EXT. OPEN OCEAN - STORM - INTERCUT

The chase, mid-fury. Oriane threads between blows. Behind the pack, apart from it, hovers a woman in dark rippling cloth that drifts as if underwater -- THE THREADWRIGHT. Her face is never shown. Her hands move in small precise gestures, and every dark figure moves as her fingers move.

A LIGHTNING BOLT takes Oriane across the cheek -- a bright scar through the crystal sheen, the aura burned dark around it. She cries out, reinforces the hollow around her body, runs on.

Her mind SPLITS -- ten parts, weaving amidst one another with coursing elation. The world within arm's reach turns hyper-vivid; the horizon smears.

EXT. UNDERWATER - THE BLOOM - INTERCUT

Silence. Full colour. The reef is a lit city of coral and fish. Two small silhouettes stroke across the bright surface far above.

Ahead of them the shelf simply ENDS -- a clean edge, and past it a lightless vertical BLACK. The boys pass over the drop, tiny above the abyss.

Deep in the black, something very large moves. We never see its shape.

EXT. OPEN OCEAN - STORM - INTERCUT

The sea ERUPTS. A LEVIATHAN the size of a city block rises and hangs in the air -- held there, impossibly, by three of the Turned. Dead coral sheets off its plating in slabs. Rows of fins span outward and inflate like leather balloons.

Fused into the crown of its skull, grown into the plating, is a man in sodden cloth. He is not riding it. He is part of it. The hide around him is stained dark for metres.

Oriane throws a hollow ahead of herself and slings sideways -- through the closing JAWS. She lands on an outstretched fin, firm and bulbous underfoot, and RUNS THE FLANK, passing fin after fin.

Iron ore spears whip past her, trailing electricity between the raindrops. She kicks two out of the air -- they punch back through two pursuers and pin them to the beast's flesh.

Hail she has frozen herself tinkles off her crystal sheen.

A bolt CONNECTS -- and does not pass through her. Caught in the hollow around her body, it circulates, a river of light held in a channel. She is lit from inside.

Oriane SMILES. Arcs of electricity spark between her teeth.

The rider hauls at the charge, trying to take it back. She lets him pull her -- rides the pull straight onto the skull -- and channels everything into ONE POINT: the lightning, a condensed spike of seawater, three stacked hollows above her driving her down, and the seized iron spears arriving from behind, all at once.

Her mind splits to SIXTEEN. Her head is screaming.

SOUND COLLAPSES to that single point --

-- then expands as one massive physical wave. The leviathan's flesh RIPPLES outward from the strike as if a meteor had crashed into a lake. Where the rider was, there is only a smooth empty hollow in the plating. The great fins fall slack.

She whispers something to the creature. It might be an apology.

EXT. KEEPER'S ISLE - BEACH - INTERCUT

The boys stagger up out of the surf, arms out, exhausted and delighted. They stretch their arms like birds flapping their wings. To the north: the white Vigil Temple, doors shut, gardens tended, utterly calm.

Out over the water, the dark cloud is nearer now.

EXT. OPEN OCEAN - STORM - INTERCUT

A spear of ore takes Oriane through the left calf -- her greave shatters outward in a rosette, its seam-light dead. Two more scratch past, scoring her flank. She tightens her fists and pushes on.

The Threadwright closes with relentless fervor.

Oriane smiles.

The Threadwright FALTERS.

Oriane releases the final barrier on her power. Sixteen pieces of mind become THIRTY-TWO -- the sky fills with translucent warping bubbles -- SIXTY-FOUR -- ONE HUNDRED

TWENTY-EIGHT. The hollows drive everything -- puppets and puppeteer alike -- toward the eye she has opened in the storm.

EXT. MACHIRA - FROM ORBIT - CONTINUOUS

TOTAL SILENCE.

From above the exosphere: the storm system far below, and at its centre an eye that is not weather -- a black puncture reaching up out of the atmosphere. Sixteen specks spiral inward along its wall and are gone.

She holds all one hundred twenty-eight pieces of her mind -
- and SPLITS THEM IN HALF, like tiny atoms. Past two hundred.

A soundless bloom of pale flame spreads across the eye and collapses inward. The Threadwright's last cry reaches no one. The storm begins, slowly, to close.

EXT. UPPER ATMOSPHERE - CONTINUOUS

Oriane falls upward, spent, the crystal sheen fracturing -- and the fractures fill with LIGHT, not dark.

The FOUNDING STONE OF HOLLOWs leaves her chest. Not torn out. Released. Green-white, ancient, lit from within.

She holds it a moment. Says something we do not hear. And THROWS it -- a green streak across the curve of the world, thousands of miles, gone.

She looks up toward the Sun -- where she knows he is watching.

Her body comes apart into particles that fall UPWARD, and disperse.

HOLD on the empty sky. Two beats longer than comfortable.

EXT. KEEPER'S ISLE - BEACH - SUNSET

The boys lie drying on warm sand. A thin GREEN STREAK crosses the sky out over the water, already fading, like a falling star that chose to rise.

Wren points at it. Neither boy knows what it is. Nobody explains it.

Then the ground JOLTS -- sand leaps from the surface. They drop flat, crawl on all fours to the nearest brush.

Out of the west, backlit by the lowering sun: twelve vast dark shapes on the water, hazed by spray -- sea monsters,

surely -- until the masts resolve. TWELVE WOODEN SHIPS,
sails billowing, advancing in line.

They open fire. A hellfire of metal falls on the Isle.

The white temple takes direct hits and does not react. Sand and torn flowers rain down its face, lit blood-red.

Directly overhead now: the dark cloud. Motionless while every other cloud moves.

WREN

(whispering)

What are they waiting for?

A great DUST STORM stirs up, obscuring all shapes into dark-brown shadow. Everything vanishes into it --

-- and out of the dust: the temple doors stand OPEN on a rectangle of blank white light. Two lines of KEEPERS walk out in undyed white robes, faces blank and calm, pace fluid and completely unhurried. There are small Keepers among them, children, walking with the same composure.

Metal pummels the sand around them. None of it touches them. They form two lines facing the sea, and stand.

Then every projectile in the air SLOWS TO A HALT, hanging amidst the suspended dust.

Only now -- with it already happening -- do the Keepers take
a knee, all bowing their heads. Not to cause it. To refuse to watch it.

The shifting sands converge on the floating metal. Rock and dead coral erupt from beneath the waves and ascend to join it. The mass merges into what can only be called a FLOATING MOUNTAIN, turning slowly.

It glides out over the twelve ships, and stops. Splashes around the hulls -- desperate souls abandoning ship.

A distant whisper. A low rumble.

The mountain comes apart into a million particles -- and they FALL, faster than gravity should allow, pounding the ships down beneath the surface.

Quiet. No ships on the sea. Nothing left in the sky. The Keepers have never raised their heads.

They stand, turn, and file back into the temple. A few fall back and move their hands: craters refill themselves, and a

trampled garden replants in moments, flowers opening as we watch. The doors close.

EXT. KEEPER'S ISLE - BEACH GRASS - GOLDEN HOUR

The boys in the grass, filthy, staring at flat water where twelve ships used to be. Wren is hysterical with excitement.

WREN

Did you know, Alder? Did you know
that they could do this?

ALDER

No...

WREN

Alder, I want that!

ALDER

I dunno...

WREN

Hey -- there were small Keepers out
there too. Imagine if we both made
it in! Mum and Dad would be so
proud.

Wren keeps talking. His voice drops away under the surf,
hands still moving.

THE CAMERA PUSHES IN -- slow, relentless, the only push-in
on this island -- on Alder's face. He is not excited. He is
calculating. Somewhere in the push his expression settles
into something that does not belong on an eight-year-old.

ALDER (V.O.)

(quiet, level)

That would be nice too. But that is
not why I want it. I want to move
mountains. To raise them up high
over the heads of my enemies. To
see the pause and regret in their
eyes, just before justice comes
raining down.

Far behind him, deep out of focus: the dark cloud, low over
the water, motionless. It has been let in.

HARD CUT TO:

EXT. THE SUN - COURTYARD OF WORLDS - CONTINUOUS

Caedom stands alone at the courtyard's edge, where two people stood before. Looking down at the blue-green world. He does not move.

ORIANE (V.O.)
He could erase everything.

CAEDOM (V.O.)
There must be risk if there is to
be growth.

The camera tilts down to the floor of light -- and finds
the

FROZEN TEAR, still lying there, unchanged.

A slow crane straight up and away, until it is a single
point of light on a vast luminous floor.

CUT TO BLACK.

TITLE: MATTER OF LIGHT

CARD: ORIGINAL SCREEN STORY BY B.L. BARKEY
ADAPTED FROM THE NOVEL "ANCHOR STONE"

FADE OUT.

THE END